

1948, September 23rd

The following is a faithful transcription of the typed original by the Servant of God, Father Solanus Casey, O.F.M. Cap.

September 23rd 1948.

Mr. Joseph J. O'Donnell.
1120 Lake Shore Drive
Chicago, Illinois.

Saint Felix Friary.
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My Dear Friend Joseph: God bless you and yours, especially Mrs; ofcourse. Just a short word Tonight to tell you a little about Rev. Father Guardian's transition, as we all hope to his better place in God's providence beyond the grave. First, however, I want to thank you for your kind favor of last week, duly received and noted as requested, which I forgot to acknowledge over the phone the night-before-last.

About a year ago Father Guardian - Mtthias - took a very threatening turn and for several months, till early March, was not really able to come down to the refectory or to choir-services. During that period he was able to sleep very little and that only in the chair. However, it would seem he'd been reading the life of one of our great modern missionaries, the late most Rev. Bishop Hartman of India, and made a novena to his honor and in petition that he do something for him, to be able at least to fulfil the principal duties of his office. At the end of the novena, thanks be to God and the great missionary, Father Guardian came to Choir and refectory and also to recreation up to the very last. Even Sunday night, just a few hours before his final sleep, he seemed even more than usually entertaining; so that one would almost think he would'nt mind conversing all night. He was always a great reader and though apparently cared little about showing his ability, the advantage of his reading and study was often manifest.

What was better, he was a man of lively faith with an unusually wide experience and with trials and hardships from early childhood that were hardly ever wanting to tame and to mellow and soften his naturally fiery nature.

Perhaps the bitterest disappointment of his whole life was that regarding his, from-early-childhood vocation to be a priest in the Capuchin-Franciscan Order; - a disappointment which having been suffered in resignation, was lifted in God's own merciful way and time; - surely an example in confirmation of St. Paul's " "For those who love God, all things turn for the best." He had become cigar-maker in early boyhood to help raise the big family, of which he was the eldest; and then a gardner and musician, etc. etc; when he learned to his great joy and hope, after as was generally thought to be too late to study for the holy Priesthood, that in America there was still a possibility of becoming a priest and at that, a Capuchin Franciscan. His smoldering hopes at once revived and as soon as possible he came to America.